



backing of the government but lacking the support of several WFI state units, allowed everyone to compete, irrespective of whether he or she represented an affiliated unit or not.

The Pune Nationals did have the support of a few state units, but it was short on quality due to the absence of some well-known wrestlers.

The Jaipur Nationals saw the absence of several state units, owing allegiance to the WFI. But it attracted elite wrestlers, including World Championship medallists Vinesh Phogat, Anshu Malik, and Sarita Mor, who aspire to compete in the Paris Olympics.

The conduct of two back-to-back National championships created a lot of confusion and insecurity among the athletes and posed more questions than answers.

Many up-and-coming wrestlers were not sure where they should compete. Selection trials conducted by various state unit factions either on identical dates or close to each

other forced some athletes to take part in as many as four competitions (two trials and two Nationals) or miss some of these. As per a rough estimate provided by an ad hoc panel official, over 50 wrestlers competed in both Nationals.

There were allegations that some wrestlers were warned not to participate in the government-approved Nationals.

Troubled past

The IOA-appointed ad hoc committee had conducted selection trials for some important international events, including the World Championships and the Asian Games.

Even after the WFI polls last year, the wrestlers objected to the election of Sanjay Singh because of Brij Bhushan's influence on him.

The Sports Ministry, taking note of Sanjay's proximity to Brij Bhushan and some 'arbitrary' decisions taken by the newly-elected body, swiftly 'suspended' the WFI and declared

Triumphant return: Vinesh Phogat, returning to the mat after 16 months, defeated Jyoti for the 55kg title.

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that the competitions conducted by the national federation would not be recognised.

It asked the IOA to form another ad-hoc body to run the WFI.

In this troubled background, with the government-mandated ad hoc committee asserting itself as the rightful body to run wrestling at the moment and the elected WFI not wanting to loosen its grip over the sport's administration, a chaotic scenario emerged.

The Railways, a public sector unit entrusted with holding the government-sanctioned National championships, made all possible efforts and pumped in significant financial resources to make the Jaipur event a success.

Railways Sports Promotion Board (RSPB) secretary Prem Chand Lochab, a wrestlers' sympathiser who was